Then there was the tragic absurdity of the letter to Palestinians published in broken Arabic in *Mishpacha*, a popular weekly newspaper for ultra-Orthodox Jews. Many had been targeted in the Old City, probably because of their conspicuous garb. Yet, the authors explained, they did not pray on the Temple Mount because their rabbis deemed it sacrilegious. Since the intifada had been kicked off by disputes about praying there, they felt they should be exempted, imploring, “please stop murdering us.”

## *A changing climate*

Netanyahu’s surprise victory in the March 2015 election had put him on course to surpass David Ben-Gurion, the founder of the state, as Israel’s longest-serving prime minister. But he didn’t seem to particularly enjoy the start of his fourth term. The government he pieced together after weeks of negotiations was Israel’s most conservative in decades; Netanyahu was actually one of its most liberal members, and he struggled to contain the hawkish impulses of his coalition partners. He had to endure a volley of criticism from the right, particularly from Lieberman, the head of a hawkish nationalist party that had initially elected to stay in the opposition. And his coalition had just 61 members, a one-seat majority in the Israeli parliament, the Knesset. This narrow margin exposed him to endless blackmail from backbenchers. Two Likud members, David Amsalem and Avraham Nagosa, hinted that they might vote against the budget unless Netanyahu agreed to bring 1,300 Falashmura—Ethiopians with a tenuous connection to Judaism—to Israel. If the budget vote failed, the Knesset would dissolve, and Netanyahu’s rule would be in danger.

So the violence compounded an already precarious situation, threatening his image as the level-headed guardian of Israel’s security, his main (arguably, his only) selling point to voters. It also opened a rift between Netanyahu and the army leadership. In February the chief of staff, General Gadi Eizenkot, urged his soldiers to exercise restraint. “When there’s a 13-year-old girl holding scissors or a knife, and there’s some distance between her and the soldiers, I don’t want to see a soldier open fire and empty his magazine,” he said at a meeting with high school students in Bat Yam.

The Israeli army, like all modern armies, has rules that govern the escalation of force. Eizenkot was merely restating those rules. Yet he was immediately attacked by politicians on the right, who accused him of